the old tsarist presence in Tehran that Curzon's policy was designed to combat is difficult to tell. Indeed, Curzon's policy towards both White and Red Russia was complex and often contradictory. From what was known and understood of Bolshevism, it was clear to London that the new regime in Moscow was a potential threat to the British Empire.[171] It was just such a danger that was used by both Curzon and Cox as a reason for forwarding Britain's presence in Persia. Furthermore, the possibility of the Bolshevik regime penetrating Persia, either politically or militarily, was one of the main reasons given for the continued maintenance of the Russian Legation and the Cossack Division.

However, as much as Curzon and Cox may have feared a Bolshevik incursion into Persia in the immediate future, it was the possibility of a resurgence of an imperial Russia that was, in their opinion, the greatest long-term threat to Britain's interests in southern Asia. Reflected in Curzon's haste to push forward his Persian policy in 1918–1919 was the belief that Britain should take the opportunity to gain the upper hand while its old imperial rival was weakened. The assumption that Russia would eventually re-constitute itself in something of its old form and try to pursue that which it had temporarily lost with the Bolshevik revolution seemed supported by the attitude of the Russian Legation and the Cossack Division in Persia. Indeed, the Great Game appeared personified in these relics of the old order and in the day-to-day feuds between the likes of Minorskii and Malleson. Yet this inability to detach his thinking from the old pattern of Anglo-Russian rivalry meant that Curzon followed a line in Persia in this period that really did seem 'quixotic', in the words of Cox: the propping-up of the imperial Russian presence in Persia, while simultaneously working to undermine its position within that country. Indeed, it is hard to understand how Curzon and Cox failed to predict the hostility that the Russian Legation and Cossack Division would have against the Anglo-Persian Agreement when it was finally made public.

And although others within the British government who were sceptical of Curzon's proposals for Persia in 1918–1919, the acting foreign secretary was able, through force of will, to push through his plans. As one historian has explained, when it came to Persia, 'Curzon was able to exploit his ministerial seniority and his special expertise in Eastern affairs to overcome